



Digital warriors: (L-R) Sanindhya Malik, Aakash Shandilya and Akshaj Shenoy in action at the 2023 Hangzhou Asian Games seeding event. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

» ASIAN GAMES SPOTLIGHT – ESPORTS

India's night-shift athletes

By day, they are engineers, designers and corporate professionals. By night, they become India's **League of Legends** team, chasing Asian Games glory from across the country.

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It's about 10 pm in Delhi, at the end of a long working weekday, when Mihir Ranjan sits down at his computer. The IIM Ahmedabad graduate works at McKinsey & Company and spends much of his day in front of a screen, immersed in the familiar rhythms of corporate life: meetings, presentations, spreadsheets, deadlines. But now, late at night, the 25-year-old has something else to look

forward to.

"Now my second life begins," he tells *Sportstar*.

He slips into something comfortable, closes his door and puts his phone on silent so he won't be disturbed. He puts on his headset and joins his teammates online on the League of Legends server. He's not Mihir Ranjan anymore, but 'Lotus'.

Joining from Kochi is Akshaj 'Katbot' Shenoy, the team's 24-year-old captain, who is preparing for his MBA while helping run his father's sanitaryware business. From Greater

Noida, cloud engineering intern Aakash 'Infi' Shandilya logs in. In Aligarh, Israr 'Nero' Ahmed is getting ready at the end of a day spent studying to be a chemical engineer. Sanindhya 'Deadcorpora' Malik joins from Mauritius, where he's working to build the island's telecommunications infrastructure. Rahul 'Bob' Bisht, a product designer and entrepreneur from Bengaluru, is there too.

Six men with entirely different lives, separated by thousands of kilometres, are about to become a team. They are preparing for the Asian Games in